

"The future belongs to those who learn more skills and combine them in creative ways."

- Robert Greene - Author

Ameren Coworker Connect – Announcement, April 20, 2025

Ameren announcing innovative tools for Collaboration, Connecting and Creating.

"Today we are excited to announce a major opportunity toward even more collaboration, which will result in added creativity in solving customer problems," said Marty Lyons, Ameren's chairman, president, and CEO. "Internal feedback and benchmarking is clear that we need collaboration for creativity, and we seek a sense of community at work. In our research, one Ameren respondent wrote, 'Jumping from in-person meeting to online meeting, doesn't leave any room for informal collaboration.' We must spend time together to expand our networks – especially our secondary networks – these are the associations that drive creativity. In turn, directly supporting our strategy pillar of optimization."

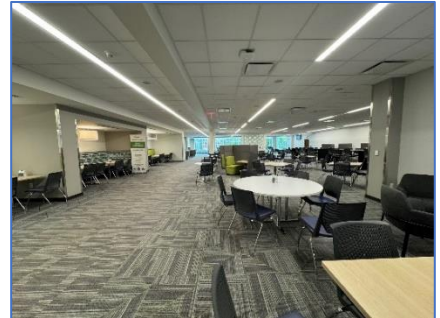
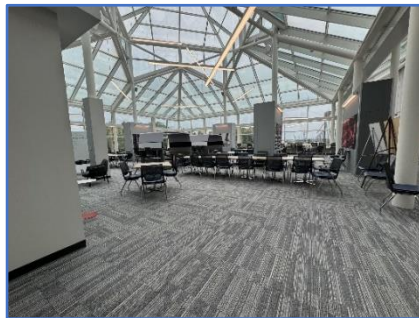
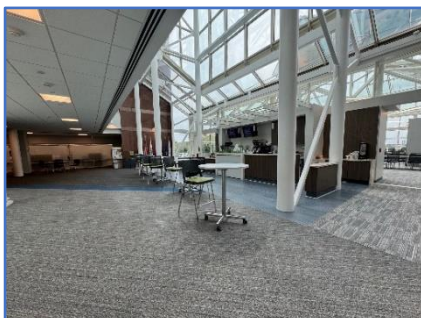
Covid significantly changed where we worked – and greatly disrupted how we work. On March 15, 2020, Ameren coworkers (about 2,500) working from Headquarters (HQ - 1901 Chouteau Avenue) were sent home to adhere to Covid safety protocols. Remote work ripped away almost any ability to maintain and grow networks beyond one's small core network. Beginning April 1, 2024, coworkers began returning to HQ at least three days per week. While coworkers were remote, the physical workspace changed dramatically. The HQ was remodeled, assigned desks

removed, internal work locations reorganized. The net impact is coworkers are showing up at HQ, only to find a quiet space to take Teams calls all day. This changes today!

"I'm so excited for this change," said Mark Lindgren, executive vice president, Corporate Communications and Chief Human Resources Officer, "To better serve customers we must evolve and optimize. This change will make it easier for us to collaborate and create. Frankly, it will make our time in HQ more enjoyable. I know the Optimizing Meeting Time, or OMT, will be a quick win. And, we want to pilot two more programs, Birdbath and Union Station, to get your feedback. In time, I think they, shaped by your feedback, will be pillars of our culture."

This change was implemented using the 7 skills practiced by successful innovators. To learn more about OMT, Birdbath and Union Station, continue reading the analysis.

Problem Statement: Work at Ameren HQ fundamentally changed due to Covid. Before Covid, Ameren was in-seat five days a week, with traditional assigned desks – and much movement around the building. During the Covid work from home period, Ameren's HQ was transformed into a new modern workspace. Such that upon the official return to work, teams and departments were relocated and no desk spaces were assigned. The result was coworkers were in HQ, but largely 'holed' up in a space in virtual meetings – often with another coworker in HQ who was doing the same. See pictures of Ameren's HQ common spaces observed 2:00 p.m. on Thursday April 25, 2024.



To address this issue, and introduce creative solutions, Ameren organized a diverse team of coworkers to utilize the seven skills of successful innovators to identify creative solutions to this problem. These strategies included key techniques of association, observation, questioning and benchmarking internal and external to Ameren. The team also leaned on diverse networks (described in the Appendix) for insights. Here are the three new concepts.

Optimize Meeting Time, or O.M.T. -- Aligning Technology to Enable Collaboration. Each day coworkers badge into the building. In addition, coworkers reserve a desk location for their day. Combining these two factors and syncing with Microsoft Office Outlook calendar means that each time a calendar appointment notification appears, it will include information such as who is currently in HQ, and where they are officing. This fifteen-minute 'heads up' alert means coworkers can get out of where they are holed up on Teams calls, and optimized their time by conducting the meeting in person.

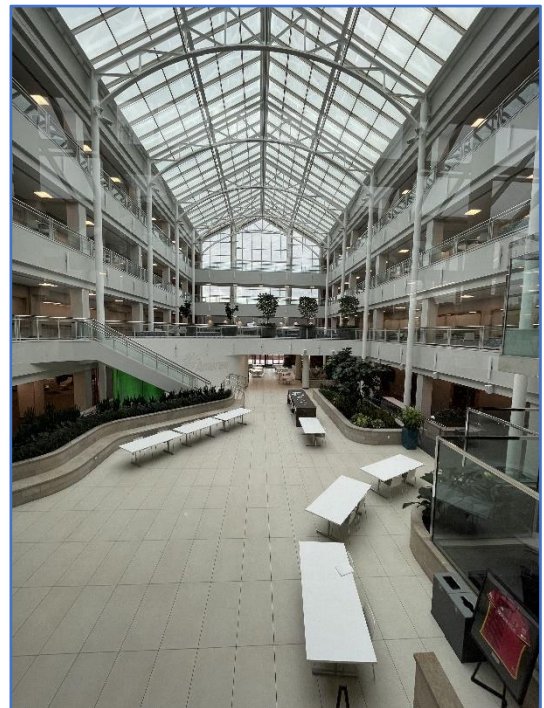
Birdbath. The team thought about nature, and what brings animals together. Imagine birds at a birdbath – they swoop in, grab a drink, cool off, and are gone. All sorts of birds come in, too...and all day. This association led to Ameren's new meet up called Birdbath. Beginning as a 90-day pilot, every Tuesday, Wednesday and Thursday, between 9:30 and 11:00 a.m. a new computer system will pull data from coworkers showing availability on Outlook calendar and in HQ. It will then prepare 30 matches within these windows of time and send in invitation. Coworkers will then meet at the Ameren Starbucks for a free coffee or specialty drink and spend 20-minutes networking with their matched co-worker. The computed match can be a pair, three or four people at a time – and for strategic reasons. Such as pairing digital coworkers

with operations, or supply chain with communications. Each coworker is encouraged to attend, share their Ameren story and current 'big wins' and 'struggles.'

Union Station. Opening in 1894, the St. Louis Union Station was the largest such building in the world with tracks and passenger service areas all on one level. In the 1940s, there were 100,000 people a day moving through the station. Ameren's Union Station program associates that story and history along with the grand hall themed architecture. It matches it with HQ's atrium space.

While our Atrium is not as ornate, it is massive, and currently underused.

For this program; each Tuesday, Wednesday and Thursday at 10:00 Ameren will be hosting a 'Union Station session' in our atrium. The Union Station is a group of about 12 Ameren coworkers coming together in the atrium to hear about an issue and share ideas. A system is set to identify coworkers with availability and send a Union Station meeting invite. The



computer system will ask for a volunteer to share, but if no one does, it will designate one person 'to share'. Sharing is a quick introduction with communicating the biggest business problem on the designated coworker's desk. After five minutes of sharing, attendees can give feedback, share related experiences to aid the problem, and make connections to other coworkers. A five-minute Computer Based Training along with a script is provided to those identified as sharing. Finally, coworkers can sign up to share a problem looking for support and solutions.

Ameren is excited about these new programs. After each Birdbath and Union Station, those invited will receive a feedback link. Programs will be added and adjusted in real time based on feedback.

"It's not how much time we spend in the office, but how we spend our in-office time," Marty Lyons concludes. "Optimizing means working together to innovate and solve problems. It's now time to move about the HQ!"

For Context and Background (examples of development and refinement of the idea):

- I started drafting this in a traditional way, following the outline of the assignment. I began to explain how I used each of the techniques. But, after a page or two in the traditional practice I asked, *what if* I frame this as an Ameren announcement to coworkers – that is what you read. My aim is to provide a more 'sticky' assignment and the use of the tools is evident in how the paper is framed. **Fingers crossed this comes across! In a sense, this is the 'pitch'.**
- As you can read, **associations** were made with technology (OMT), nature (Birdbath) and St. Louis history and architecture (Union Station). Initially, it was just the use of technology, but further work using the brainstorming technics from our class allowed the concepts to grow and blossom.
- For **benchmarking and networking**, I used some current but mostly dormant networks and used both my STL region and DC area networks for feedback; and one EMBA contact. Outline and verbatim feedback below. There is some great feedback with a number of insights directly incorporated in the paper.

- For **experimenting**, I met with Ameren's senior strategy manager to review the concepts. He encouraged additional thinking about 'what's next.' Is this just a 'one off' or is there more layers to add to increase the growth of coworkers and the benefits of these programs.
- There is a bit of 'inside' Ameren baseball and jargon. For example, Ameren's strategy is based on three pillars, Invest, Enhance and Optimize, so the use of 'optimize' in this paper has meaning to Ameren's team ([See slide 7 in this deck for strategy](#)).

Addendum:

Network Outreach Summary:

Ted Power, AB (STL network/dormant network)

Pat Justus, Ameren (dormant network)

Jonathan Hirte, DTE (DC network/dormant network)

Sandi Hennequin, Libery Utilities (DC network/dormant network)

Rob Dixon, Amren (current network)

Tony Lozano, Ameren (current network)

Pat Justis, Ameren (dormant network)

Christian Rusteberg, Ameren (dormant network) – and met with Christian to review this concept

Swastika Bungley, Bayer (EMBA network)

Drue Duncan, Pfiser (both STL and DC, and dormant. Responded that he would follow up, but did not)

From: Powers, Ted M. <ted.powers@anheuser-busch.com>
Sent: Monday, April 29, 2024 10:35 AM
To: Forck, Matthew A <MForck@ameren.com>
Subject: [EXTERNAL] RE: quick question!

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Hi Matt,

Hope all is well with you. Here are a few points:

- Has your firm officially returned to office? If yes, approximately when, and are there so many required in office days per week?

Yes, I believe it was early 2022 when the full-time return policy commenced. Some groups are very strict about it, and others are not. However, working from home is far more flexible across the entire company than pre-covid. It is a hugely valuable benefit for employees to have flexibility when needed. Our brewery employees never ceased working full-time.

- How is collaboration and connecting within the office a problem, post Covid? (Good. Bad. About the same as before Covid?)

For the groups that allow more frequent working from home, it does not seem to be an issue. Communications are such that many times it is not even realized when people are not physically present.

- Has your firm implemented any solutions to improve collaboration and connectivity?

We do have a more robust program of employee engagement (softball teams, lunches, happy hours, etc.) so as to encourage interaction.

- Have you all implemented, or considered implementing, any technology driven solutions?

Ha – zoom calls are our life!!

- Any advice for us (Ameren) in this process?

It seems like it has evolved at A-B about the way that makes sense. A formal policy that mandates working in the office, but with significant flexibility for employees in groups where flexibility is not a hinderance to collaboration and productivity. Groups in which in-person collaboration is required don't benefit as much from that flexibility, but that is not a reason to prevent others from utilizing that work-from-home option.

From: Forck, Matthew A <MForck@ameren.com>

Sent: Friday, April 26, 2024 1:58 PM

To: Justis, Pat E <PJustis2@ameren.com>

Subject: quick question...

Pat,

Good afternoon! I hope this email finds you well – and look forward to catching up soon!

I'm working on a project and am being encouraged to reach outside my immediate circle for insights. Below are five questions. Please, don't spend more than 100 seconds on this – if you could share a bullet point on each, that would be terrific.

Thanks in advance, and talk soon. Matt.

Quick Questions:

- How is collaboration and connecting within the office, post Covid? (Good. Bad. About the same as before Covid?). *Pretty good with my EE team.*
- Has your team implemented any solutions to improve collaboration and connectivity? *Heavier use of shared One Note and use of cameras for Teams calls/meetings, plus intentional aligned days in office as well as all-team biweekly mtgs. Before cutbacks, was doing all-team team-building twice per year.*
- If yes, (you have implemented or considered implementing solutions) are they technology driven solutions? *While some of these are technology, they are not necessarily novel or innovative technology-driven solutions you may be contemplating.*
- What if Ameren had a couple of new processes to pull people together in small groups (two to five people), for a quick 20 minute huddle about once every 90 days (and free coffee!), would that of interest to you? How do you think your team would respond to something like this? *I think my team would enjoy it.*
- Any advice for me (and my team) in this process? *Not sure exactly what you're after but sounds like identifying additional ways/aids for collaborating. I think when folks are happy with their work environment and empowered to engage as an owner of their part of the business, they readily collaborate.*

From: Sandi Hennequin <Sandi.Hennequin@libertyutilities.com>
Sent: Friday, April 26, 2024 3:43 PM
To: Forck, Matthew A <MForck@ameren.com>
Cc: Dale Harrington <Dale.Harrington@libertyutilities.com>
Subject: [EXTERNAL] RE: quick question...

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Hi Matt,

Glad to help and look forward to catching up soon. I copied Dale Harrington, our Central region HR lead in case there are some variances/nuances for Central to note.

Let me know if you have any follow up questions.

Have a good weekend!
Sandi

Sandi Hennequin | [Liberty Algonquin Business Services \(USA\)](#) | Vice President, Governmental Affairs
C: 603-828-9729 | E: Sandi.Hennequin@libertyutilities.com

From: Forck, Matthew A <MForck@ameren.com>
Sent: Friday, April 26, 2024 2:54 PM
To: Sandi Hennequin <Sandi.Hennequin@libertyutilities.com>
Subject: quick question...

Sandi,

Good afternoon! I hope this email finds you well – and look forward to catching up soon!

I'm working on a project for Ameren here at our HQ, and am being encouraged to reach outside for insights, especially to similar energy companies. Below are five questions. Please, don't spend more than 100 seconds on this – if you could share a bullet point on each, that would be terrific.

Thanks in advance, and talk soon. Matt.

Quick Questions:

- Has your firm officially returned to office? If yes, approximately when, and are there so many required in office days per week? It varies a little bit by location but typically yes and it is generally 3 days (TWR) per week and the various groups try to chose the same day(s) to come in
- How is collaboration and connecting within the office a problem, post Covid? (Good. Bad. About the same as before Covid?) Mixed – there is less time in the office and some people (like me) have gone 100% remote. I would say when people are in the office there is more collaboration and connection because it is more planned, and some people structure their work to do the head down/tail up solo work at home whereas the group or meeting accountabilities happen in the office.
- Has your firm implemented any solutions to improve collaboration and connectivity? I am not sure they are solutions for this but we do annual engagement surveys and periodic pulse surveys and we take the results seriously, charging teams with developing action plans to address weaknesses. We have other longer standing practices like Liberty Days (three days paid off a year to do community projects, preferably as a team in the service areas), town halls, and then celebrations around holidays/annual events like lineworker appreciation days in the various offices. Some groups (like mine) that are scattered to regular happy hours or social check ins (originated with COVID) or things like coffee pals.
- Have you all implemented, or considered implementing, any technology driven solutions? Not sure – this may be a better Dale question
- Any advice for us (Ameren) in this process? Keeping in mind the almost expectation that no one goes into an office 5 days a week anymore (especially among Millennials and Gen Z) and this type of policy wouldn't be well received and could be a deterrent for recruiting or retention). But also keep in mind that with no office time we are losing the natural mentorship and professional development that comes from unscheduled water cooler conversations or popping in someone's office. Trying to find that balance. And if you find it, share it with others!

Hope this is helpful – I am sure Dale's insights will be more helpful than mine! Sandi

From: Dixon, Rob B <RDixon@ameren.com>
Sent: Friday, April 26, 2024 5:00 PM
To: Forck, Matthew A <MForck@ameren.com>
Subject: RE: quick questions...

Hi, Matt. Happy Friday! Responses below. Let me know if there's anything further I can do to help with this.

Rob Dixon, Senior Director – Economic, Community, and Business Development
Ameren Missouri

From: Forck, Matthew A <MForck@ameren.com>
Sent: Friday, April 26, 2024 2:00 PM
To: Dixon, Rob B <RDixon@ameren.com>
Subject: quick questions...

Rob,

Good afternoon! I hope this email finds you well.

I'm working on a project and am being encouraged to reach outside my immediate circle for insights. Below are five questions. Please, don't spend more than 100 seconds on this – if you could share a bullet point on each, that would be terrific (first thing that come to mind).

Thanks in advance, and talk soon. Matt.

Quick Questions:

- How is collaboration and connecting within the office, post Covid? (Good. Bad. About the same as before Covid?). *It's good overall. Different from pre-covid. Now, even though it's good to be near people in the office to connect informally, the mish-mash of in person & virtual meetings makes it physically difficult to build on the in-person interactions. Jumping from in-person meeting to online meeting, doesn't leave any room for informal collaboration.*
- Has your team implemented any solutions to improve collaboration and connectivity? *We've implemented a regular weekly meeting where leaders from the entire org gather to meet on strategy execution. Each team gets visibility into what the others are doing. This leads to "spontaneous" opportunities to collaborate in real time during the meeting, and it also, more importantly, leads to shared awareness of each others' goals and objectives. Currently, this meeting is for all our people leaders and a few SMEs. We are considering expanding it to the entire org to gain the same visibility. (This is loosely based on the "Team of Teams" framework.)*
- If yes, (you have implemented or considered implementing solutions) are they technology driven solutions? *For the above, we use Microsoft Planner, which creates a*

shared space where we can all see and access each other's main activities and tactics that are executing our strategy. Planner allows for easy project management.

- What if Ameren had a couple of new processes to pull people together in small groups (two to five people), for a quick 20 minute huddle about once every 90 days (and free coffee!), would that of interest to you? How do you think your team would respond to something like this? It needs to be relevant to what we're working on, rather than something that seems like a "corporate" wellness initiative. Coworkers are feeling the strain of various priorities right now, and this would need to support progress towards those, rather than feel like an additional item added on.
- Any advice for me (and my team) in this process?

From: Bungley, Swastika <b.swastika@wustl.edu>
Sent: Tuesday, April 30, 2024 6:59 AM
To: Forck, Matt <f.matt@wustl.edu>
Subject: Re: quick question...

Hey Matt,

Hope all is well :)
Here you go.. good luck and thanks for reaching out for my perspective!

Quick Questions:

- Has your firm officially returned to office? If yes, approximately when, and are there so many required in office days per week?

No yet, but there are talks about returning to office 3 days a week. I assume that will begin in the last quarter of 2024/beginning of 2025.

- Is collaboration and connecting within the office a problem, post Covid? (Good. Bad. About the same as before Covid?)

I wouldn't say it is a problem, but it's different. For work related topics it was reported that productivity increased, however it is not very clear how long it took someone to solve a problem. Surveys reported that employees worked longer hours compared to pre covid. The depth of personal connections were definitely impacted due to the lack of "water-cooler" conversations about the family or life in general.

- Has your firm implemented any solutions to improve collaboration and connectivity?

Other than the teams/zoom meetings, we started using other tools like Miro/Mural for workshopping. We tried hybrid summits instead of all in person, by bringing in small groups of people in a room(s) while the remainder of the audience were online. While people adapt to these situations, the energy is not the same as in a physical summit.

- Have you all implemented, or considered implementing, any technology driven solutions?

Some are mentioned above. We also started considering some AR/VR solutions for auditing (can be used for other purposes also, like training) , so as to limit auditors to have to visit plants but still ensure that audits continue to happen.

- Any advice for us (Ameren) in this process?

Personally, I would suggest maybe starting a couple of quick pilot programs to try different approaches tailored to different r groups and then learning from there before a standard protocol is set in place again.

Thanks,
Swastika

Get [Outlook for iOS](#)

From: Lozano, Antonio M <ALozano2@ameren.com>
Sent: Friday, April 26, 2024 4:46 PM
To: Forck, Matthew A <MForck@ameren.com>
Subject: RE: quick questions...

Hey, good afternoon!

Of course. **My gut reactions to each are below.** Please don't hesitate to let me know if you'd like to talk about any/all of it further.

Thanks,

Antonio Lozano
Ameren Missouri
T 314.861.3232
C 314.604.5260

From: Forck, Matthew A <MForck@ameren.com>
Sent: Friday, April 26, 2024 2:00 PM
To: Lozano, Antonio M <ALozano2@ameren.com>
Subject: quick questions...

Tony,

Good afternoon! I hope this email finds you well.

I'm working on a project and am being encouraged to reach outside my immediate circle for insights Below are five questions. Please, don't spend more than 100 seconds on this – if you could share a bullet point on each, that would be terrific (first thing that come to mind).

Thanks in advance, and talk soon. Matt.

Quick Questions:

- How is collaboration and connecting within the office, post Covid? (Good. Bad. About the same as before Covid?) **Worse than before. Combination of exponential reliance on technology, increasing data combined with decreasing knowledge, more "stuff" formally being schedule for everyone at all levels, dramatically decreasing emotional intelligence, and a general lack of desire for many to want to be a reciprocal part of a community. Many want to be around a community, or have that as a talking point, but don't want to act themselves as part of that community.**
- Has your team implemented any solutions to improve collaboration and connectivity? **Yes. Visual management with specific cadence, standard work and role definitions to intentionally drive discussion. Includes formal structure on items like recognition, informal feedback horizontally and vertically, soft skills development (e.g., negotiation skills) and gratitude/celebrations**

- If yes, (you have implemented or considered implementing solutions) are they technology driven solutions? No, but technology is used to support/document in many ways, allowing the current state/live version of the effort to be available to all folks at anytime from anywhere.
- What if Ameren had a couple of new processes to pull people together in small groups (two to five people), for a quick 20 minute huddle about once every 90 days (and free coffee!), would that of interest to you? How do you think your team would respond to something like this? Depends on how it ties into me and my teams role and what we need to be accomplishing. ERGs already are trying versions of this, and at the corporate, segment and function levels, I am seeing a real hard time getting folks to engage at all levels.
- Any advice for me (and my team) in this process? These are great questions. Just note that right now, time along with the items I talked about above, is a bigger hurdle to cutting through the noise for folks that just about anything else.

From: Rusteberg, Christian <CRusteberg@ameren.com>
Sent: Friday, April 26, 2024 3:41 PM
To: Forck, Matthew A <MForck@ameren.com>
Subject: RE: quick questions...

Hey Matt,

Good to hear from you. Thanks for thinking of me as a resource. Please see my responses below.

From: Forck, Matthew A <MForck@ameren.com>
Sent: Friday, April 26, 2024 2:01 PM
To: Rusteberg, Christian <CRusteberg@ameren.com>
Subject: quick questions...

Christian,

Good afternoon! I hope this email finds you well.

I'm working on a project and am being encouraged to reach outside my immediate circle for insights. Below are five questions. Please, don't spend more than 100 seconds on this – if you could share a bullet point on each, that would be terrific (first thing that come to mind).

Thanks in advance, and talk soon. Matt.

BTW, let's catch up soon!

Quick Questions:

- How is collaboration and connecting within the office, post Covid? (Good. Bad. About the same as before Covid?) [Better than during Covid but not as good as having people in the same desk whenever you need/want to talk to them.](#)
- Has your team implemented any solutions to improve collaboration and connectivity? [Aside from the mandatory 3 days a week, no.](#)
- If yes, (you have implemented or considered implementing solutions) are they technology driven solutions?
- What if Ameren had a couple of new processes to pull people together in small groups (two to five people), for a quick 20 minute huddle about once every 90 days (and free coffee!), would that of interest to you? How do you think your team would respond to something like this? [That would interest me from the stand point of meeting new people but not collaborating with people I already know.](#)
- Any advice for me (and my team) in this process? [Director led, Executive sponsored small cross functional meet & greets are a good way to encourage collaboration. Of](#)

course, including multiple members of your team would encourage them to chat amongst themselves as well, building some team comradery.

From: Jonathan Hirte <jonathan.hirte@dteenergy.com>
Sent: Friday, April 26, 2024 5:37 PM
To: Forck, Matthew A <MForck@ameren.com>
Subject: Re: [EXTERNAL] quick question!

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Good to hear from you, Matt! I took a stab at most of these questions. Hope it's helpful!

Jonathan

From: Forck, Matthew A <MForck@ameren.com>
Sent: Friday, April 26, 2024 2:52 PM
To: Jonathan Hirte <jonathan.hirte@dteenergy.com>
Subject: [EXTERNAL] quick question!

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Jonathan,

Good afternoon! I hope this email finds you well – and look forward to catching up soon!

I'm working on a project for Ameren here at our HQ, and am being encouraged to reach outside for insights, especially to similar energy companies, like DTE. Below are five questions. Please, don't spend more than 100 seconds on this – if you could share a bullet point on each, that would be terrific.

Thanks in advance, and talk soon. Matt.

Quick Questions:

- Has your firm officially returned to office? If yes, approximately when, and are there so many required in office days per week?

We are in the process of implementing a three days per week in office schedule. Our Senior Leader Team and Directors have completed this move. Managers, supervisors and individual contributors will move to three days per week in July.

- How is collaboration and connecting within the office a problem, post Covid? (Good. Bad. About the same as before Covid?). **It hasn't been as good as pre-Covid, which is why we've determined that great in-person engagement is necessary to foster collaboration, engagement and a stronger company culture.**
- Has your firm implemented any solutions to improve collaboration and connectivity?
- Have you all implemented, or considered implementing, any technology driven solutions?
All of our conference rooms are Microsoft Teams enabled
- Any advice for us (Ameren) in this process?
Our experience is still playing out, but it seems like providing a long lead time for employees to adapt their schedules and routines is necessary. Having senior leaders return first with frontline employees making the move six months later seems to have set the right example and minimized some of the consternation from employees who would prefer to remain remote in perpetuity

Idea development report. The goal of this report is to provide you an opportunity to start working on an idea (or refine an already existing idea) that you would like to pitch. The 7 skills introduced in class are those practiced by successful innovators and are key to you being able to consistently develop and sell your new ideas. Thus, in preparation for your report, I am asking you to systematically practice these skills, as well as their associated techniques:

1. **Associating**—combining ideas/concepts from disparate knowledge domains (technique: brut force, identify analogous problem domains)
2. **Observing**—seeing the world with fresh eyes to generate new understandings or to test untested assumptions (e.g., Oral-B, Old Spice) (technique: think like an anthropologist)
3. **Questioning**—challenging every assumption (technique: reverse assumptions) and using constraints to structure the solution space (technique: suggestive/prohibitive constraints & 21 great questions)
4. **Networking**—seeking out social intersections by reaching out to people who are otherwise disconnected (technique: activate your dormant ties)
5. **Experimenting**—trying out your ideas and testing assumptions underlying them by creating dirty prototypes of your new product, service, process, or procedure (technique: rapid prototyping)
6. **Teaming**—harnessing the power of diverse teams by imposing a structured process and instilling appropriate team norms (technique: hybrid approach to brainstorming)
7. **Pitching**—selling your ideas so that they become sticky (technique: SUCCES formula)